

7.5 Pick Up Your Paintbrush

If you've always wanted to create your own Lightsaber effect à la Star Wars, you need to use a technique called *rotoscoping*. It involves tracing live-action movement in videos frame by frame, and painting over it. You can use this to either mix your own drawings over live video, or with some meticulous work, create your own cartoon out of real-life footage.

To use rotoscoping in Wax, you need to use the RotoMate plugin from the Video Plugins tab.

The most basic thing you can do with RotoMate is create a slideshow of sorts of your paintings. To get started, pick a movie or image to start on, and drag the RotoMate plugin on to it. You can use the button on the left of the plugin track to open the RotoMate toolbox next to your movie, and use the paintbrush to start painting. Once you've painted a shape, it remains persistent on your movie till the frame where you decide to paint another shape. The old one then vanishes and gives way to the new one. Try it—draw a line, move ahead in the timeline, then draw another line.

If you select the “Shapes as Mask” option, you will end up with a black background, and every shape you paint over it will let some part of the underlying movie show through. This is especially useful if you want to isolate one part of the movie and keying isn't working for you.

In the example, we've got a walking bug against a complex background, but we still want just that single element. In the RotoMate Toolbox, we'll pull down the Onion Skin parameter to let the movie show through so we know where to paint.

Unfortunately, you'll have to repeat this step for each frame of your movie—at the very least, for each frame that your character is moving—very time-consuming work.